

SEVEN-G – Document 9

Phase Gate & Audit Criteria Guide

1. Purpose of this Document

This document defines the mandatory audit criteria, objectives, and documentary completeness requirements that must be satisfied to pass each SEVEN-G phase gate. A phase is considered complete only when both phase objectives and all associated documentary artifacts are validated.

2. Binding Nature of Gate Criteria

Gate criteria defined in this document are normative and binding. Failure to meet any mandatory criterion results in a non-GO decision. Partial fulfillment may only result in ITERATE or GO WITH CONDITIONS, never in unconditional GO.

3. Dual Validation Model

Each phase is validated on two independent dimensions: (1) Objective achievement and (2) Documentary completeness. Both dimensions must pass for the phase to be considered successful.

4. Roles in Gate Validation

Gate validation requires explicit participation of the AI Sponsor, AI Risk Owner, and AI Auditor. The AI Product Owner and AI Technical Owner may provide evidence but may not self-approve a Gate.

Phase 0 – Context & Constraints Definition

Objectives

Strategic intent is explicitly defined. Regulatory, ethical, budgetary, and organizational constraints are documented and approved.

Mandatory Documents

AI Initiative Charter; Context & Constraints Statement; Initial Role Assignment Record.

Audit Criteria

Objectives aligned with enterprise strategy; constraints explicitly documented; roles formally assigned.

Gate Outcomes

GO / ITERATE / STOP

Phase 1 – Opportunity Discovery

Objectives

AI-suitable opportunities are identified and prioritized based on business relevance.

Mandatory Documents

Opportunity Backlog; Opportunity Screening Notes.

Audit Criteria

Opportunities are business-driven; non-AI-suitable cases are explicitly excluded.

Gate Outcomes

GO / ITERATE / STOP

Phase 2 – Value Hypothesis

Objectives

Each opportunity has a measurable and falsifiable value hypothesis.

Mandatory Documents

Value Hypothesis Canvas; Baseline Metrics Definition.

Audit Criteria

Metrics are measurable; baseline exists; success criteria are explicit.

Gate Outcomes

GO / ITERATE / PIVOT / STOP

Phase 3 – Feasibility & Risk Gate

Objectives

Technical, economic, and risk feasibility are validated.

Mandatory Documents

Feasibility Assessment; Risk Matrix; Risk Register; Mitigation & Contingency Plan.

Audit Criteria

No unmitigated high-risk items; feasibility validated by independent review.

Gate Outcomes

GO / ITERATE / STOP

Phase 4 – Solution Design

Objectives

Solution architecture and governance controls are fully defined.

Mandatory Documents

System Architecture Record; Data & Model Lineage; Governance Design.

Audit Criteria

Architecture supports auditability, monitoring, and rollback.

Gate Outcomes

GO / ITERATE / STOP

Phase 5 – Delivery & Validation

Objectives

Solution is deployed and validated in production or production-like environment.

Mandatory Documents

Delivery Report; Validation Results; Updated Risk Register.

Audit Criteria

Production evidence exists; validation metrics collected.

Gate Outcomes

GO / ITERATE / STOP

Phase 6 – AI Ops & Governance

Objectives

AI system is operationally stable and governed.

Mandatory Documents

AI Ops Runbook; Monitoring & Alerting Configuration; Incident Response Plan.

Audit Criteria

Operational controls active; ownership clearly assigned.

Gate Outcomes

GO / ITERATE / STOP

Phase 7 – Feedback, Iteration & Scaling

Objectives

System evolution, scaling, or retirement decisions are evidence-based.

Mandatory Documents

Value Realization Tracker; Scaling or Retirement Decision Record.

Audit Criteria

Decisions based on production metrics and maturity level.

Gate Outcomes

GO / SCALE / ITERATE / RETIRE

Final Note on Audit Enforcement

Any attempt to bypass gate criteria, retroactively fill documents, or self-approve a phase constitutes a governance violation. Auditors are mandated to issue a FAIL outcome in such cases.